

The Sleeve-Shaped Harbor: Hakata Before and After the Grid

Hakata traded with the Asian mainland while Kyoto was still building its first palaces, survived two Mongol invasion fleets, and was burned to nothing by retreating samurai in 1586 — only for Toyotomi Hideyoshi to redraw it from scratch a year later. A river was straightened to bury the old harbor; a monk brought back noodles and a festival. This dossier follows the port from its sleeve-shaped inlet to its twin-town grid.



博多（福岡市博多区）

In this dossier

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Written in English from Japanese library sources — chiefly books digitised by the National Diet Library — and official records. Superscript numbers point to the numbered sources at the end, with page frames for the digitised books.

A harbor shaped like a sleeve

Long before Hakata had streets, it had an inlet. An Edo-period gazetteer of the district describes a bay that once ran from east of the town westward to the Naka River, curving north then west so that, in the writer's words, it looked like the shape of a sleeve — hence its name, Sode-no-Minato, the Sleeve Harbor. The same book repeats, carefully labelling it a local legend rather than established fact, an old story that the god Susanoo once set out from this very inlet for Silla on the Korean peninsula. Whatever the truth of that tale, the inlet was real, and for centuries it was Hakata's harbor.¹

It was real enough, in fact, to host one of only three official guesthouses ancient Japan built for foreign envoys. First recorded in 688 as Tsukushi-no-Murotsumi and later renamed Korokan in Chinese style, Fukuoka's guesthouse operated from the late Asuka period into the late Heian period, receiving diplomats, monks and traders from Tang China, Silla and beyond; of the three such halls built at the capital, at Naniwa and here, only this one has been located and excavated. Workers renovating a baseball stadium's outfield stands found the first traces — Chinese and Islamic ceramics and West Asian glassware — in December 1987; the stadium itself came down ten years later so archaeologists could finish the job, and the site became a national historic site in 2004.⁴

Stones from an invasion fleet

Hakata Bay was also where Japan's most famous foreign invasion broke apart. Kublai Khan's fleets came ashore near here in 1274 and again in 1281; a defensive stone wall the shogunate ordered built along the bay after the first invasion still survives in fragments elsewhere in Fukuoka, and this district's own harbor kept a stranger relic. A 1944 Fukuoka Prefecture survey of Mongol-invasion sites records stone ships' anchors dredged up from the floor of Hakata's modern port during harbor works, still lying, by the surveyor's account, exactly where the old Sode-no-Minato inlet had opened onto the sea in the thirteenth century; one, cut from stone quarried in southern Korea and crusted with centuries of shell growth, was reckoned to have lain on the seabed for some 666 years, dating it to the first invasion of 1274.²

That particular stone did not stay in a museum case. On 17 December 1940, in a ceremony whose text the same survey reproduces in full, port officials presented it to Miyazaki Shrine, dedicated to the emperor under whose reign the invasions had failed, with prayers invoking Kublai Khan by name and the "divine wind" that had scattered his ships. The ceremony belongs to its moment — wartime Japan reached eagerly for the story of a foreign fleet destroyed by providence — but the stone itself is a genuine, datable fragment of 1274, recovered from the very ground this district's harbor now occupies.²

A monk, a noodle and a vanishing harbor

Medieval Hakata's most productive foreign import may have been a Song-dynasty Chinese monk's education. The priest Enni, later honored as Shoichi Kokushi, returned from years of study in China in 1241 and founded the temple of Jotenji the following year; with him, Fukuoka City's own account of the district's food culture holds, came the milling techniques behind udon, soba, manju and yokan, which he is said to have taught to a Hakata teahouse keeper before the recipes spread nationwide with the tea ceremony. Two years after his return, in 1243, the same monk is credited with a stranger legacy still practiced every summer: riding a ritual platform through Hakata's streets, sprinkling purified water to pray away an epidemic, in what the city's own cultural-property records treat as the origin of the Hakata Gion Yamakasa festival.⁵⁷

Not far from Jotenji stood Shofuku-ji, honored with a plaque in the retired emperor Go-Toba's own hand naming it Japan's first Zen meditation hall. Between these temples and the merchant quarter, Hakata's medieval prosperity and its harbor's slow disappearance were more connected than they might seem: the same 1921 edition of an old district gazetteer credits the Otomo retainer Usuki Awa-no-kami with straightening the meandering Hie River into a direct channel through the pine groves near these temples in the 1570s — the ancestor of today's Mikasa River — which cut off the water feeding Sode-no-Minato and let the old inlet silt over for good. Villagers digging in the area a century later, the gazetteer notes, still turned up seaweed and shells in what was by then dry ground.¹

Burned down, then redrawn

Hakata paid for the long Sengoku wars in full. In 1586 the Shimazu clan, occupying the town and hearing of Toyotomi Hideyoshi's approaching army, burned Hakata to the ground as they withdrew. The following year, having conquered Kyushu, Hideyoshi ordered the town rebuilt from nothing, and the result, still known as the Taiko Machiwari, is the grid that much of old Hakata's street plan still follows: his commanders Kuroda Kanbei and Ishida Mitsunari carried out the planning, while the merchants Kamiya Sotan and Shimai Soshitsu — two of the men later remembered as Hakata's three great merchant princes, along with Oga Soku — helped fund and organize the rebuilding. Kushida Shrine, Hakata's guardian shrine since a tradition dates one of its enshrined deities to 757, received Hideyoshi's patronage in the same reconstruction, and its present main hall dates from that campaign.⁶⁹

Hakata's merchants kept the town's older, foreign-facing character even after Hideyoshi's rebuilding. When Kuroda Nagamasa, known by his Buddhist name Josui, took possession of the domain in 1601, he lodged for a time in Kamiya Sotan's own Hakata house before building Fukuoka Castle on the Naka River's western bank — founding, in effect, a twin town: merchant Hakata on the river's east side, samurai Fukuoka on its west, sharing a name for the modern city but keeping separate identities for centuries after. Hakata's own Gion-cho neighborhoods were organized into five-household groups in 1612 and given a rotating board of year-officers in 1621, machinery for self-government that outlasted the merchant princes who had first rebuilt the town.¹

A city burned again, and rebuilt again

Hakata's grid survived nearly three and a half centuries before fire returned. On the night of 19 June 1945, 221 American B-29 bombers spent roughly two hours over Fukuoka, burning out an area of some 3.78 square kilometres of the city. The national government's own postwar accounting gives 902 dead, 1,078 injured and 244 more listed missing, with 2,693 households destroyed and the city's water, gas and electricity systems wrecked along with its schools, hospitals and factories. Recovery work began that January, and by 1949 the city's population had climbed back to roughly 370,000.⁸

Reading the ground today

Kushida Shrine still stands where Hideyoshi's carpenters rebuilt it, and every July its precinct fills with the six decorated floats of the Hakata Gion Yamakasa, racing before dawn on the 15th over a course of about four kilometres — a nationally designated Important Intangible Folk Cultural Property since long before UNESCO added it to its own world list in 2016. A short walk away, Jotenji keeps its own marker to the udon-and-soba legend Enni is said to have brought home in the thirteenth century, in a temple compound that has stood, rebuilt more than once, on essentially the same ground since 1242.⁵⁷

The Korokan's excavated foundations are laid out for visitors on Fukuoka Castle's grounds today, close enough to the shoreline of Hakata Bay to make the ancient guesthouse's seafront position easy to picture even though the old inlet it once faced is long since built over. Between the shrine, the temple and the excavated foundations, this small district holds physical traces of a foreign guesthouse older than Kyoto's own imperial court records, a fleet the sea itself is said to have destroyed, and a town two different rulers each burned and rebuilt from the ground up.⁴

Timeline

688	Tsukushi-no-Murotsumi, later renamed Korokan, is first recorded as a guesthouse for foreign envoys. ⁴
757 (tradition)	One of Kushida Shrine's three enshrined deities is dated by tradition to this year. ⁹
1241–42	The monk Enni returns from Song China and founds Jotenji, reputedly bringing udon- and soba-making methods with him. ⁵
1243	Enni's epidemic-prayer procession through Hakata is credited as the origin of the Gion Yamakasa festival. ⁷
1274 and 1281	Mongol invasion fleets land in Hakata Bay; a stone anchor from the first fleet is later dredged from the harbor. ²
1570s	Usuki Awa-no-kami straightens the Hie River, cutting off the water feeding the Sode-no-Minato inlet. ¹
1586	The withdrawing Shimazu clan burns Hakata to the ground. ⁶
1587	Toyotomi Hideyoshi orders Hakata rebuilt on a new grid, the Taiko Machiwari. ⁶
1601	Kuroda Nagamasa (Josui) lodges with the merchant Kamiya Sotan before building Fukuoka Castle across the river. ¹
1612–21	Hakata's Gion-cho neighborhoods are organized into five-household groups, then given rotating year-officers. ¹
1940 (17 Dec)	A dredged Mongol-invasion anchor stone is ceremonially dedicated at Miyazaki Shrine. ²
1945 (19 Jun)	An American air raid kills 902 people by the government's own postwar count and burns much of the city. ⁸
1987–2004	The Korokan's foundations are discovered, excavated and designated a national historic site. ⁴
2016	Hakata Gion Yamakasa is added to UNESCO's Intangible Cultural Heritage list. ⁷

Walking notes

Places to stand and look, in walking order. Straight-line distances only; check today's access and opening before you go.

- 1 Korokan Historic Site and Museum** 鴻臚館跡展示館. The excavated foundations of Japan's only confirmed ancient diplomatic guesthouse, on the grounds it shares with Fukuoka Castle; imported ceramics and glass found here are on display.⁴
- 2 Kushida Shrine** 櫛田神社. Hakata's guardian shrine, rebuilt in Hideyoshi's 1587 reconstruction; look for the display float kept year-round and, every July, the six competing Yamakasa themselves.^{6 7 9}
- 3 Jotenji** 承天寺. Founded in 1242 by the monk Enni; a stone marker inside commemorates the temple's traditional role in bringing udon- and soba-making to Japan.⁵
- 4 The Reisen neighborhood and the old Hakata grid** 冷泉町付近の町割り. Streets and block widths here still trace the 1587 Taiko Machiwari grid, laid out after the Shimazu burned the medieval town.⁶
- 5 The Naka River between Hakata and Fukuoka** 那珂川. The river Kuroda Nagamasa chose as the boundary between his new castle town of Fukuoka and the older merchant town of Hakata in 1601, a division the two place names still preserve.¹

The same ground, 1945–1950 and 2020



1945–1950 aerial photograph (US military photography) — GSI Tiles *ort_USA10*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. North is up; the frame is identical in both images.



2020 annual orthophoto — GSI Tiles *nendophoto2020*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. Capture dates within a mosaic can differ from place to place.

How to compare. Anchor on features that rarely move — river banks, rail lines, shrine and temple grounds, main roads — then look for what changed around them. Differences in tone come from film, camera and season, not from the land itself.

The decades in between

Every further GSI series that covers the same frame, oldest first. Each series is a compilation: photographs within one series were taken on different dates, which is why seams and changes of tone can appear inside a frame.



1961–1969 · GSI Tiles *ort_old10*, processed

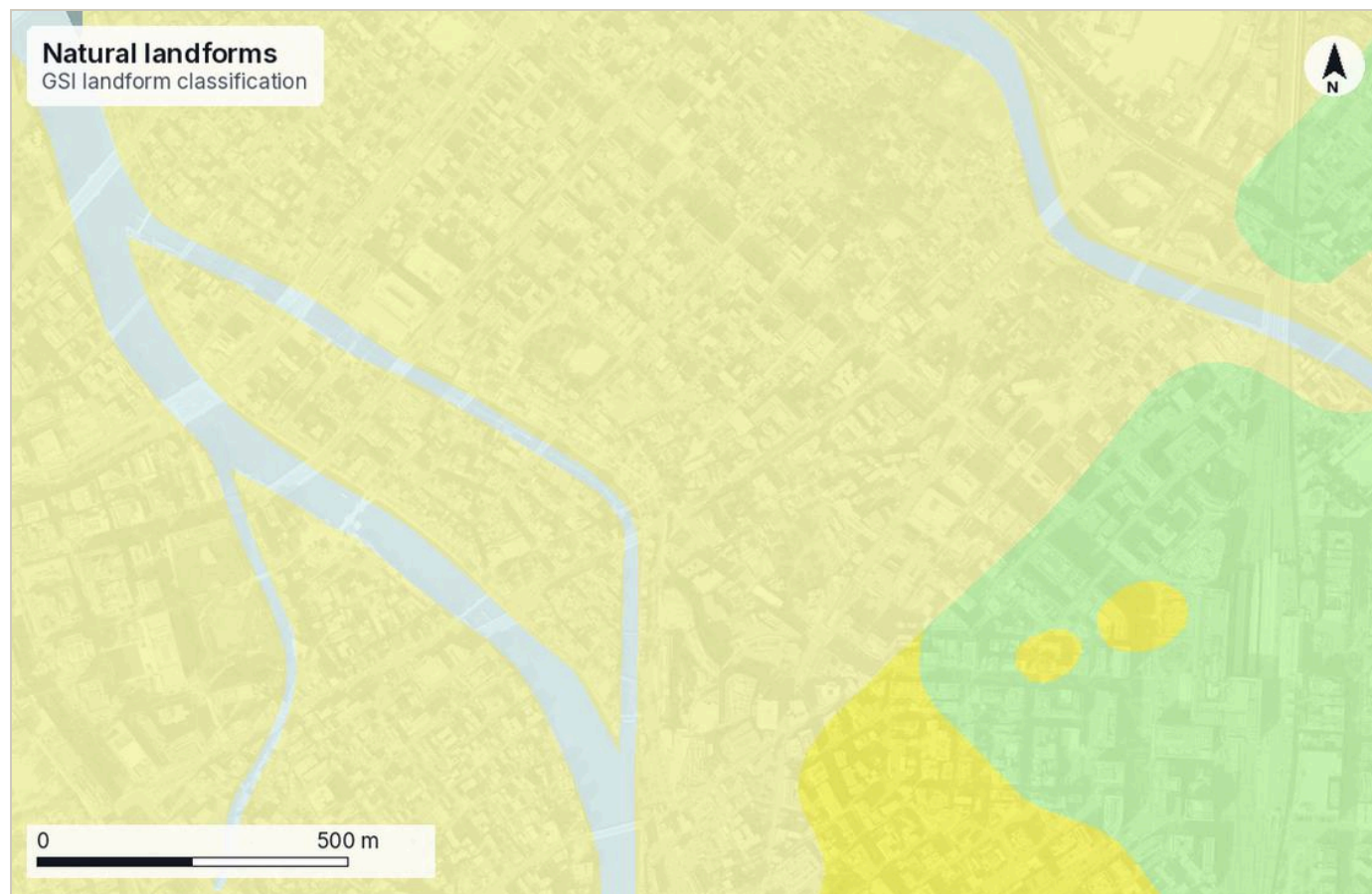


1974–1978 · GSI Tiles *gazo1*, processed



1987–1990 · GSI Tiles *gazo4*, processed

Rivers, shorelines and terraces



Natural landforms as classified by GSI, over a recent aerial photograph in gray. Dark blue outlines mark former river channels.

 Sandbars and dunes 72%	 Floodplain and coastal plain 16%
 Water 7.6%	 Natural levee 4.6%

What the main landforms mean

Sandbars and dunes (72%). Sandy or gravelly ground higher than its surroundings along present or former coasts, lakeshores and riverbanks, built by waves or wind. Usually escapes ordinary floods. Liquefaction tendency is somewhat strong on sandbars, somewhat weak on dunes and very strong at dune margins.

Floodplain and coastal plain (16%). Low, flat ground of little relief, built from sand and mud left by floods, or former seabed that emerged. River flooding. Ground is softer nearer the coast and shakes somewhat more; liquefaction tendency is strong on coastal plains and somewhat strong on floodplains. Storm surge near the coast.

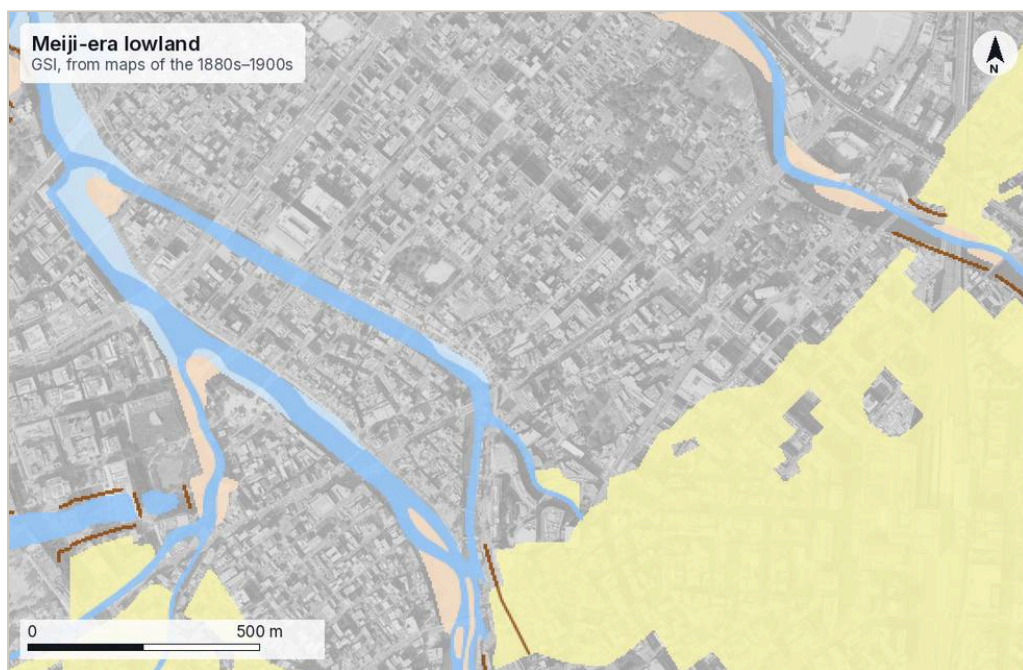
Natural levee (4.6%). Long, low ridges 0.5 m to a few metres above their surroundings along present or former rivers, built from sediment dropped by floods. Usually above ordinary floods but can be covered in major ones; strong liquefaction tendency at the edges.

Descriptions translated and condensed from GSI's landform-classification legend. They describe tendencies of each landform type, not the condition of any individual plot.

Fill, reclamation and the fields beneath the town



Hatching: man-made ground as classified by GSI. Teal outlines: former sea, river or pond. Dark blue outlines: former river channels.



GSI “Meiji-era lowland” data, traced from topographic maps of the 1880s–1900s; GSI warns that positions can be off by a considerable distance, especially in the Kanto and Kinki regions. Only low, wet or open ground was traced: towns, dry fields and forest of the period are left blank.

Man-made ground

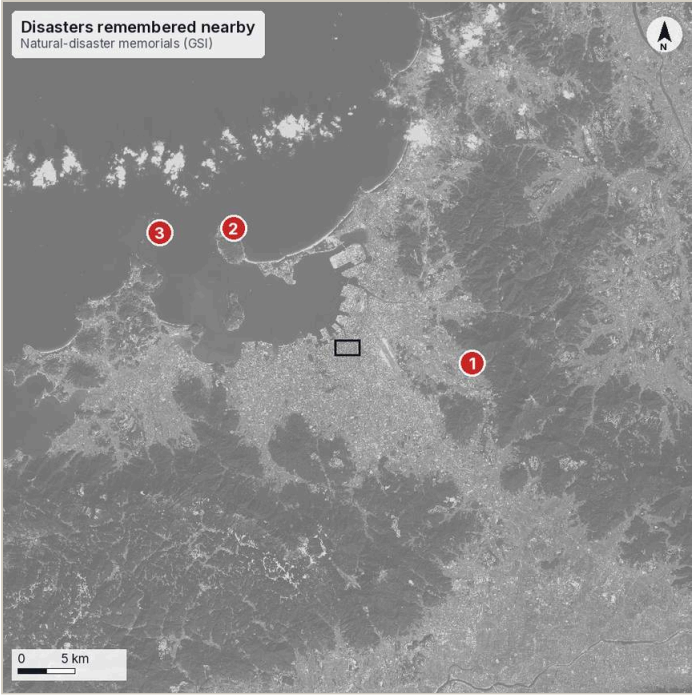
 Filled and reclaimed land 16%

Meiji-era lowland

-  Rice paddy 25%
-  River, pond or sea 5.1%
-  Sand and gravel 1.6%
-  Tidal flat or beach 1.4%

Filled and reclaimed land (16%). Ground raised with fill, land made by dumping soil into the sea, rivers or ponds, or valleys filled in. May flood if not raised enough; on hills, rain or earthquakes can make the fill fail; in lowlands the liquefaction tendency is very strong, especially on filled sea, lake or river beds.

Memorials to natural disasters nearby



Numbered memorials; the black rectangle is the study area of this brief. Frame 60 km across.

Fewer than three memorials stand within 3 km of the study area, so the nearest ones within 30 km are listed.

	Memorial	Disaster	Erected	Distance
1	Monument to the recovery from the 1973 flood in Satani 水害復興碑	Torrential rain (31 Jul 1973) · flood / landslide or debris flow	1976	11.0 km
2	Monument to the recovery from the 2005 Fukuoka earthquake (Katsuma) 福岡県西方沖地震復興記念碑	Earthquake west off Fukuoka Prefecture (20 Mar 2005) · earthquake	2006	14.4 km
3	Monument to Genkai Island's recovery from the 2005 Fukuoka earthquake 福岡県西方沖地震復興記念碑	Earthquake west off Fukuoka Prefecture (20 Mar 2005) · earthquake	2008	19.2 km

What the memorials record

- 1. Monument to the recovery from the 1973 flood in Satani.** Before dawn on 31 July 1973 torrential rain dropped 239 mm on Sue in just two hours. In the Satani district, debris flows and other damage killed 2 people, destroyed 21 houses and half-destroyed 6, flooded 31, and washed away or buried 23.8 hectares of farmland.
- 2. Monument to the recovery from the 2005 Fukuoka earthquake (Katsuma).** On 20 March 2005 a magnitude 7.0 earthquake centred in the Genkai Sea off Fukuoka City, with a seismic intensity of 6 lower on the Japanese scale, closed roads with slope collapses and damaged houses.
- 3. Monument to Genkai Island's recovery from the 2005 Fukuoka earthquake.** On 20 March 2005 a magnitude 7.0 earthquake centred in the Genkai Sea off Fukuoka City, with a seismic intensity of 6 lower on the Japanese scale, devastated Genkai Island: 19 people were injured and 214 homes damaged, 107 of them completely destroyed.

Source: GSI Natural Disaster Memorials (自然災害伝承碑). English names and notes are Japan Time Atlas translations and summaries of GSI's Japanese descriptions; the memorials' own inscriptions may say more. "Erected" is the year GSI records for the monument.

Sources

1. 津田元貴 著 (Tsuda Motozane), 石城志 [Record of Sekijo (a historical gazetteer of Hakata)], 1921; NDL frames 26, 31, 32. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/987296/1/26> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: The Sode-no-Minato inlet's shape and legend; Kuroda Nagamasa's 1601 arrival; Hakata's neighborhood organization in 1612 and 1621; Usuki Awa-no-kami's rerouting of the Hie River and the silting-over of the old harbor.
2. 福岡県 編 (Fukuoka Prefecture), 福岡県史蹟名勝天然記念物調査報告書 第14輯 元寇史蹟地之巻 [Fukuoka Prefecture survey of historic sites, scenic spots and natural monuments, vol. 14: Mongol-invasion sites], 1944; NDL frames 39, 40. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/1071986/1/39> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: A stone anchor from a Mongol invasion ship dredged from Hakata's harbor and dated to 1274, and the text of its 1940 dedication ceremony at Miyazaki Shrine.
3. [公刊者不詳], 福博商工事情：附・名勝旧跡観光案内 [Commercial and industrial conditions of Fukuoka-Hakata, with a guide to scenic and historic sites], 1941; NDL frames 54, 55. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/1090360/1/54> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: Shofuku-ji's imperial "first Zen temple" plaque, Jotenji's National Treasure statue, and the three Hakata merchants Shimai Soshitsu, Kamiya Sotan and Oga Soku.
4. 鴻臚館跡 [The Korokan ruins], 福岡市の文化財 (City of Fukuoka, Cultural Properties Database). https://bunkazai.city.fukuoka.lg.jp/cultural_properties/detail/61, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The Korokan's operating period, its 1987 discovery, 1997 excavation and 2004 national historic site designation.
5. うどんも、そばも、まんじゅうも、博多発祥 [Udon, soba and manju all began in Hakata], 福岡市 (City of Fukuoka). <https://showcase.city.fukuoka.lg.jp/column/clm0025.html>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Enni's 1241 return from Song China and the tradition crediting him with introducing udon, soba and manju to Japan.
6. 博多旧市街エリア（秀吉と博多の豪商コース） [The old Hakata townscape area (the Hideyoshi and Hakata's great merchants route)], よかなび（福岡市観光情報サイト） (Yokanavi, the official Fukuoka City tourism site). <https://yokanavi.com/route/123254/>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The 1586 destruction of Hakata by the Shimazu and the 1587 Taiko Machiware reconstruction led by Kuroda Kanbei, Ishida Mitsunari, Kamiya Sotan and Shimai Soshitsu.
7. 博多祇園山笠行事 [The Hakata Gion Yamakasa festival], 福岡市の文化財 (City of Fukuoka, Cultural Properties Database). https://bunkazai.city.fukuoka.lg.jp/cultural_properties/detail/119, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The 1243 origin legend involving Enni, the festival's cultural-property and UNESCO status, and its present-day course and date.
8. 福岡市における戦災の状況（福岡県） [The state of war damage in Fukuoka City (Fukuoka Prefecture)], 総務省 (Ministry of Internal Affairs and Communications). https://www.soumu.go.jp/main_sosiki/daijinkanbou/sensai/situation/state/kyushu_01.html, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Official casualty and damage figures for the 19 June 1945 air raid on Fukuoka and the postwar recovery timeline.
9. 櫛田神社 [Kushida Shrine], クロスロードふくおか（公益社団法人福岡県観光連盟）. <https://www.crossroadfukuoka.jp/spot/12510>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The founding traditions of Kushida Shrine's three enshrined deities (757, undated, and 941) and the dating of its present main hall to Hideyoshi's reconstruction.

Further reading

- 新修 福岡市史（福岡市 編，進行中） — Fukuoka City's own modern official history project, cited by several of the official pages used in this dossier; consult the city archives or central library for volumes covering the medieval and early-modern port. <https://www.city.fukuoka.lg.jp/> (print only)
- 福岡県史資料 第9輯（福岡県 編，1938） — Contains reproduced Kushida Shrine documents (櫛田神社文書); a further primary-document source for the shrine's medieval history beyond what this dossier could confirm from other frames. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/1207977> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login))
- 福岡県史資料 第3輯（福岡県 編，1935） — Further Fukuoka Prefecture historical documents from the same series as the Mongol-invasion survey cited here (S2), covering other aspects of the Hakata region's history. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/1213869> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login))
- 博多物語（竹田秋楼 著，1920） — A collection of Hakata anecdotes and traditions on theatre, the Matsu-bayashi New Year procession and sumo; this session was not able to match its full-text search hits to reliably readable frames, so it is listed rather than cited. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/960993> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login))
- 元寇防塁関係資料（福岡県内各市町村読本・郷土資料類） — The full 1944 survey volume cited as S2 also documents the Genko Borui stone wall itself at other sites around Hakata Bay in more detail than this dossier's Hakata-port-specific citation covers. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/1071986> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login))

Where a Deep Research request would go next

- **Excavation reports and finds registers for the Korokan site beyond what is on public display** — Fukuoka City Archaeological Center (福岡市埋蔵文化財センター) and the Korokan Site Exhibition Hall's own research division. Contact the exhibition hall directly for excavation-report access; the city archaeological center holds the full finds catalogue from the 1987-97 digs.

- **Full documentary and artifact records for the Genko Boruli defensive wall and other Mongol-invasion remains around Hakata Bay** — Fukuoka City Museum and Fukuoka Prefecture's cultural properties division, successor to the 1944 survey team behind S2. Search the museum's collection database for 元寇防壘 and 碇石 (anchor stone); ask the prefectural cultural properties division for the original 1944 survey's full site inventory.
- **Original Kushida Shrine documents (櫛田神社文書) reproduced in Fukuoka Prefecture's 1938 historical materials volume** — Kushida Shrine's own archive and Fukuoka Prefectural Library. Read the reproduced documents in 1207977 (furtherReading) first, then request access to any surviving originals through the shrine's office.
- **Household and leasehold records for individual blocks of the 1587 Taiko Machiwari grid** — Fukuoka City Archives and the Hakata Machiya Furusatokan (a preserved townhouse and local museum in the old grid). Contact the Furusatokan for guidance on surviving cadastral records; the city archives can advise on Edo-period Hakata town registers.
- **US mission records and target photographs for the 19 June 1945 raid on Fukuoka** — US National Archives (NARA), RG 18 (20th Air Force mission folders) and RG 243 (US Strategic Bombing Survey). Search the NARA online catalog by Fukuoka and June 1945; many mission reports are already digitized and can be ordered as reproductions.

Caveats

- The Sode-no-Minato inlet's founding legend, involving the god Susanoo sailing to Silla, is presented by the Edo-period gazetteer used here as unverified local tradition, not established history, and is treated the same way in this dossier.
- Sources differ by two years on Enni's dates: his return from Song China is dated to 1241, while the epidemic-prayer procession credited as the origin of the Gion Yamakasa festival is dated to 1243; these are treated here as two distinct, sequential events rather than a discrepancy.
- This dossier does not give an exact founding year for Shofuku-ji beyond noting its traditional status, confirmed by an imperial plaque, as Japan's first Zen meditation hall; a specific founding date could not be verified from a source opened in this session.
- The 1940 dedication ceremony for the Mongol-invasion anchor stone is described here in its wartime context; its Shinto prayer text, which this dossier does not translate in full, reflects the nationalist framing of that specific moment rather than this dossier's own view of the events of 1274.

Digitised books are cited, not reproduced: the page frames let you open the same page in the NDL Digital Collections. Aerial photographs, landform and memorial data: GSI, processed by Japan Time Atlas. This experimental edition is a draft for testing the product and has not had independent fact-checking.